



HARQUEBUSES

Simple hand-cannon remained in use into the 16th century. These evolved into harquebuses (hook guns)—muzzle-loaders with a recoil-absorbing hook on the underside to place over a wall or portable support for a steadier aim. Key to their development was a wooden shoulder stock that allowed the user to brace the gun with his shoulder, a feature that led to the evolution of the modern gun stock. Harquebuses were fired by a handheld match-cord, and they used lead balls. A harquebus modified by attaching a matchlock (see p.22) gave rise to the first musket.



Wooden stave inserted under armpit

Hexagonal barrel



Flared muzzle

▲ HANDGUN

Date	c.1500
Origin	Europe
Barrel	38¼in (97cm)
Caliber	.80in (20mm)

Although basic, this handgun is very well made, with a strong hexagonal bronze barrel, a contoured iron hook, and a fitted wooden stave. It also has a flared muzzle, a feature designed to protect the end of the barrel from potential damage.

Contoured hook



Hook

Rear sight

Stock



Recess for matchlock mechanism